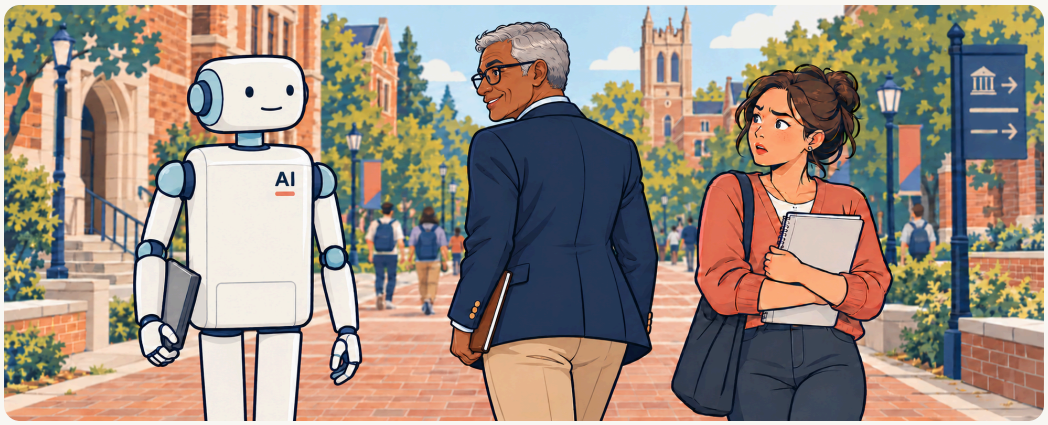
The Vanishing Apprentice

AI may narrow the first steps into expertise. Universities can build new routes.

Christopher Rogers

Entry-level work can be where people first practice judgment, receive feedback, and learn what responsibility requires. If AI reduces those opportunities, we risk losing more than first jobs. We risk weakening the pathways through which novices become capable professionals.



01 / THE FAMILIAR SEQUENCE

Learn → Credential → Experience

02 / BUILD EXPERIENCE INTO THE LEARNING

01	02	03	04
Experience →	Reflect →	Learn →	Demonstrate Capability

↶ Repeat with feedback and increasing responsibility. Credit recognizes demonstrated learning.

03 / THE SIGNAL

Evidence worth acting on

Stanford researchers report weaker employment among young workers in AI-exposed occupations. These are descriptive indicators, not causal estimates; the study does not establish that AI caused the pattern.[1]

04 / THE RESPONSE

Make the work consequential

Build credit-bearing work around real partner needs. Pair responsibility with faculty guidance, reflection, feedback, and assessment. Students explain their decisions and demonstrate what they can do.

05 / MAKE THE ROUTE DURABLE

Resolve the frictions that keep good ideas temporary

Academic credit	Define learning outcomes, assessment, and how credit counts toward a degree.
Incentives	Recognize mentoring and coordination in faculty workload and rewards.
Scheduling	Protect shared project time across courses, disciplines, and partner calendars.
Partners	Assign an owner; agree on scope, supervision, feedback, and continuity.
Funding	Fund coordination and student support so participation does not depend on unpaid work.

Universities of every size and reputation can lead.

Establish credit, ownership, and recurring support. Build a pathway students can count on beyond a single pilot.

1. Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, Canaries in the Coal Mine? Stanford Digital Economy Lab, revised August 12, 2026.
The learning route and institutional commitments above are proposals, not findings of the Stanford study.